

categorically ruled out any knowledge or complicity of the government vis-a-vis the goings-on in Murshidabad. The timing of the response, close to the Hindenburg expose on January 24-25, is being seen by many as a belated piece of self-exoneration. Despite the government's professions of innocence, Farakka BDO Ahmed admits to the police *bandobast*. "There was no agreement as such between the government and the Adani Group. It was a case of private purchase of land directly from landowners. But we gave necessary support for maintaining law and order," he says.

Rights activist and APDR member Ranjit Sur says villagers were neither consulted nor was there a discussion on compensation, as mandated by the Electricity Act, 2003, the Telegraph Act, 1885 and the West Bengal Trees (Protection and Conservation in Non-Forest Areas) Act, 2006. In its petition, APDR has demanded the formation of a high-powered expert committee under court supervision to assess the impact of the project. The PIL states that villagers should be compensated either in terms of an annual lease or with a share of Adani's profit. ■



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**CM AGAINST EX-CM**
Far left, Conrad Sangma meets supporters in Tura, Feb. 13; Mukul Sangma at a rally in North Garo Hills

For both Conrad and Mukul, the challenge is not just to dominate over the other in the 24 Garo Hill seats but to fight the perception of Garo dominance among the Khasis and Jaintias. Other Meghalaya parties, particularly those originating in Khasi Hills, hope to cash in on this sentiment. Beyond the accusation of Garo bias that he shares with Conrad, Mukul faces another identity crisis. The TMC is viewed by indigenous tribes as a "Bengali party". The state has witnessed violent clashes between tribals and Bengalis in the past. Mukul's supporters, though, say the former CM's personal popularity is enough to neutralise such perception as Meghalaya mostly votes for candidates, not on party lines.

**CONRAD AND MUKUL SANGMA BOTH HAVE TO FIGHT THE PERCEPTION OF GARO BIAS AMONG KHASIS, JAINTIAS**

That, precisely, is the reason why it has been an open season for defectors. Even the TMC's emergence as the principal opposition party happened overnight in November 2021 when Mukul and 11 other Congress MLAs joined it. Since then, nearly two dozen Meghalaya MLAs have quit their parties. The BJP, which won only two seats in 2018, is hoping for a two-digit tally by fielding turncoats. In fact, the two current MLAs of BJP, Sanbor Shullai and Alexander Laloo Hek, have won on tickets of other parties in the past—Shullai on an NCP ticket and Hek from the Congress.

Both Conrad and Mukul face challenges in their own constituencies. According to a conspiracy theory, the BJP, which played kingmaker last time by ensuring that smaller parties sided with the NPP, doesn't want Conrad to be in the saddle given his ambition to make NPP a pan-Northeast party and his adverse stand on issues such as CAA and AFSPA. If Conrad requires the BJP's services again, the latter may fuel the demand for a non-Garo CM from a smaller party, which may tighten its grip on the government. Such theories got further credence as PM Narendra Modi took the battle to his former ally by addressing a rally on February 18 in Tura, the bastion of Conrad.

Mukul is contesting from two seats—Songsak and Tikrikilla—prompting his detractors to say he is not confident of a victory. In Songsak, he faces two-time MLA Nihim Shira of NPP, whom he had defeated by a small margin of less than 2,000 votes in 2018. But Tikrikilla is the more embarrassing contest. The sitting MLA, Jimmy Sangma, who had switched from Congress to TMC along with Mukul, is now contesting as an NPP candidate, making it a prestige battle. In any event, the results that come in on March 2 are likely to be just a passing milestone in a story of rivalries: between two Sangmas and a larger inter-ethnic one. ■